# Something Went Wrong

## By Matt Casarino

*The front door opens. In comes HARRY, dragging a dead clown behind him. After quite a struggle, Harry maneuvers the clown into the middle of the room and plops down on his chair, exhausted. We see that a kitchen knife is sticking out of the clown's back.*

**MELISSA:** *(offstage)* Harry, is that you?

**HARRY:** Yeah.

**MELISSA:** *(offstage)* I'll bring in the silverware and plates, okay?

**HARRY:** Okay. Can you get me a beer?

**MELISSA:** *(offstage)* Okay. *(A few beats pass. Melissa enters)* I hope you wanted Budweiser, because that's all we . . . *(She sees the dead clown. She stops and stares for several beats, taking it in. Meanwhile, Harry takes the beer and opens it.)* Harry? What is this?

**HARRY:** Hmm? *(Another beat)* Oh, the takeout. Sorry. I didn't get it. Something went wrong.

**MELISSA:** But you did bring home a dead clown. It is dead, isn't it?

**HARRY:** *(With a chuckle)* Oh, yeah.

**MELISSA:** Harry? Is there something you'd like to tell me?

**HARRY:** No, not really *(Beat)* Hey, how about I order a pizza?

## INTRODUCTION

***ACTRESS:*** *Every marriage has conflicts.*
***ACTOR:*** *You are right . . . Problems in a marriage are inevitable. But the question is whether the couple can communicate effectively enough to resolve their problems or do they instead ignore*
***ACTRESS:*** *"the elephant in the room."*
***ACTOR:*** *Many married couples would rather ignore their problems, hoping that if they don't acknowledge them the will simply disappear.*
***ACTRESS:*** *. . . . They have the same empty conversations over and over, resolving nothing.*
***ACTOR:*** *Resentment moves in and humor and affection leave . . .*

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***ACTRESS:*** *Harry and Melissa have ignored their marital problems*
***ACTOR:*** *(their elephant)*
***ACTRESS:*** *for far too long.*
***ACTOR:*** *But Harry has a solution. He replaces their metaphorical elephant with a very real, very dead clown.*
***ACTRESS:*** *(Gives Actor an incredulous and shocked look, shaking her head)*
***ACTOR:*** *I didn't say it was a GOOD solution!*
***TOGETHER:*** *Something Went Wrong by Matt Casarino*

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**MELISSA:** Harry – Why is there a dead clown on my living room rug?

**HARRY:** *(Big sigh)* It's been a long day, Melissa. All I want to do is read the paper and eat some pizza and watch Law and Order and go to bed. Okay?

**MELISSA:** No, Harry, It's not okay. There is a dead clown with a knife in its back on my . . . hey! *(She goes to the corpse and pulls the knife from its back)* That's my good kitchen knife!

**HARRY:** Oh, yeah. Sorry about that.

**MELISSA:** Oh, my god, Harry . . . what did you do? What is going on!

**HARRY:** Honey, nothing's going on. I love you. You know that.

**MELISSA:** Harry . . . did you kill this clown? Did you?

**HARRY:** Honey . . . *(another big sigh)* . . . Okay, I'll tell you all about it. I left work and s topped at Freddie's for some takeout. But when I came home, I didn't have the takeout. Instead, I had a dead clown. So I dragged him in here and sat down. That's what happened.

**MELISSA:** But something happened in between the time you went to Freddie's and the time you brought the dead clown home.

**HARRY:** Honey, look. There is nothing I could possibly say that could even come close to justifying why I brought home this dead clown. You're

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just setting yourself up for a big letdown. Let's just say that something went wrong. What's done is done. You know, someday we'll look back on this and laugh.

**MELISSA:** I don't care about someday. I care about today. Right now. Where it's just you and me and . . . *(she motions to the clown)!*

**HARRY:** All right, Melissa. I get it. I see what's going on here. You're still made about last Thursday.

**MELISSA:** What!?

**HARRY:** Honey, I told you. The boss handed me that report to finish. I would have called, but the phones were on the fritz, so I . . .

**MELISSA:** I don't care about last Thursday night, Harry!

**HARRY:** Oh, Melissa. I've been married to you for eight years. I can read you like a book. You're still mad.

**MELISSA:** Of course I'm mad! You . . . you brought . . .

**HARRY:** I know, honey, and I admit that this (indicates the clown) is a problem. But nothing is stronger than the foundation of our love! One dead clown can't ruin that. Besides, I thought you didn't like clowns.

**MELISSA:** I like clowns!

**HARRY:** Really? I never did. They always scared me. It's like, this is supposed to make me laugh? A middle-aged fat guy in white makeup with a distorted red nose? Come on!

**MELISSA:** Clowns are supposed to be happy. They're supposed to be silly and carefree and bring joy to the hearts of children. They're not supposed to be lying dead in my living room, still bleeding from a wound caused by my kitchen knife! Can you even begin to understand

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how this makes me feel?

**HARRY:** Of course I understand. But I don't think you're making an effort to understand me. Look at yourself! You're exhibiting very hostile body language, Melissa. I don't think anything I say is going to get through right now.

**MELISSA:** Harry!! What is going on!!

**HARRY:** Honey, look. We could get into a big discussion over this, and hash out who did what, and why, and to whom, and oh my god, what about the cops, et cetera, et cetera. Instead, how about this idea. You tell me what you want on your pizza. We'll stash the clown body in the closet, then I'll call Testa's and order the pizza. We'll relax, eat dinner, drink some wine, and when we're done, we'll cut this poor bastard up and buy him in the woods in a shallow grave and put this whole dead clown business behind us once and for all. What do you say?

**MELISSA:** *(Beat)* Who are you?

**HARRY:** I'm me, Melissa. I'm the same man you've been in love with all these years. I'm just going through a tough time right now.

**MELISSA:** A tough time? My god, Harry, you . . . okay. Whatever happened, you can tell me. Okay? I'm . . . I'm your wife. I'm here to support you. So please, tell me what happened, and we can sit down, and decide what to do. Together. Okay? Now please tell me what happened.

**HARRY:** Okay. I'll tell you. Now remember how much I love you. I'd do anything for you. Keep that in mind for me okay? . . . *(Big sigh)* There was no report to finish. I was with someone.

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**MELISSA:** What?

**HARRY:** Last Thursday night. I'm so sorry, honey. I was in a bad place. I was feeling very vulnerable. I want you to know I take full responsibility for my actions. I don't blame you one bit.

**MELISSA:** What are you . . . blame me for what?

**HARRY:** Blame you for not . . . well, honey, you haven't been entirely . . . intimate with me for a while. But in all fairness, I suppose I've been distant lately, and . . .

**MELISSA:** Distant? Is that what you call it? When our entire conversation anymore revolves around dinner and which rerun we're going to watch?

**HARRY:** Hey, now that's not fair. It takes two to have a conversation, you know.

**MELISSA:** And what does that mean? That this is somehow my fault?

**HARRY:** No, no. I told you, I take all the blame. Besides, it's not like I had actual intercourse with her. I couldn't go through with it. I love you, Melissa. I could never be . . . intimate with another woman.

**MELISSA:** Harry, that doesn't . . . *(beat)* . . . wait a minute! We are not talking about your stupid little affair! We are talking about this dead clown! Now you tell me what happened, or I swear to god, Harry, soon there will be two clowns on my living room rug.

**HARRY:** I already told you. Something went wrong . . . We're talking about the clown.

**MELISSA:** YES!!!

**HARRY:** Or are we talking about us? What happened to us, Melissa? We used to have so much fun together, you and me. We would spend

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hours just laughing. What happened, honey? What happened to the laughter? *(Harry and Melissa both look at the clown)* Well. I'm sorry, honey. I really am. It's not you. It's me, it's all me. I've changed. I used to have such ambitions, such ideals. And now look at me. I'm out of shape. I'm a corporate drone. I'm . . .

**MELISSA:** You're a guy who brings home dead clowns.

**HARRY:** One dead clown. . . It's not over for us, Melissa. Someday you'll learn to trust me again, and we'll be all the more stronger for it. I told you I couldn't go through with it, honey. The flesh was willing but the heart – ah, the heart was . . .

**MELISSA:** Harry . . . Listen to me. Okay? Listen carefully. I don't care. I don't care about your stupid little non-affair.

**HARRY:** Do you really mean that?

**MELISSA:** Yes. I really mean it.

**HARRY:** Then there is hope for us! I knew it, honey. I knew we were strong enough to get past this and move forward! Let this day be the day of our rebirth! Look out, world . . . here comes Harry and Melissa, and nothing can stop them!

**MELISSA:** I don't think so, Harry. *(She raises the knife and starts to advance on him)* See, I can get past last Thursday night. Your pathetic affairs mean nothing to me Harry. I can get past that. Just as I can get past the fact that you need to buy a new case of Bud every four days. I can even get past that collection of porn that you keep under the floorboard. Oh, yeah. I know about that. Just like I know that you steal salt shakes from fast food restaurants. You see, these are things that happen in a marriage. These are the day to day issues

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that one must face and deal with and rise above. And I can deal with those issues, Harry. I have risen above. In fact, there's only one thing I'm still struggling with. One issue I just can't seem to get past. Do you know what it is?

**HARRY:** My back hair?

**MELISSA:** The dead clown on my living room rug!! Now I'm going to ask you one more time before I stab you in your bald spot. Tell me, for the love of God, why is there a dead clown on my living room rug? *(By now she's standing over him, knife ready to strike.)*

**HARRY:** *(Feeling threatened)* Honey, look, sometimes things happen and. . . . *(Melissa raises the knife and Harry cowers further)* Darling, now this in not a constructive . . . *(Melissa jerks the knife up and is ready to strike; Harry tries one last ditch effort)* Don't you think there are some things that we just shouldn't talk about?

*(Melissa stops. A few beats pass as she takes this in. She jerks the knife up again and is prepared to strike Harry . . . but she stops short. Finally, she lowers the knife, slumps her shoulders, and looks at Harry.)*

**MELISSA:** Maybe you're right. . . Yeah. Maybe some things just shouldn't be talked about.

**HARRY:** That's my girl. Hey, come here.

**MELISSA:** *(With a sigh that registers a touch of defeat)* Okay. *(Melissa tosses the knife into the back of the clown corpse. She sits next to Harry, who takes her in his arms.)* You're buying me a new knife.

**HARRY:** Of course I will. Hey, I'll order that pizza now. Pepperoni and mushroom okay? . . . we're going to be all right, honey. You'll see. *(Beat)* Oh, and honey? . . . Can you do me one favor?

**MELISSA:** What?

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**HARRY:** Don't look in the trunk, okay?

*(On her reaction . . . lights down, end of scene)*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

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